



Make A Web-based E-mail Form Using PHP

Want visitors on your Web site to leave feedback and contact you? Here's how to do it free of cost while ensuring a minimum of effort for visitors

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Consider this scenario—you have a Web site but you haven't yet set up e-mail IDs on it. Or for some reason you wouldn't like to do so (maybe because it's so tedious!).

However, if you have a Web site and would like to receive feedback or communication from your clients or visitors, you must have a business e-mail ID (xyz@yourcompany.com). To have a Yahoo! or Hotmail address for business purposes is not only un-chic, it also seems downright unprofessional.

Regardless of whether or not you have a business e-mail ID, you may feel it takes a lot of effort on the part of the visitor or client to e-mail you. You may even want to do away with the e-mail addresses given in the 'Contact Us' page.

Let's take a look at what it takes to build a Web-based form ('Contact', 'Feedback', what have you) using PHP (Hypertext Pre-Processor, an HTML-embedded scripting language). You won't believe how easy it is. What's more, there are no restrictions on the number of forms you can create! However, to understand this workshop, a basic idea of HTML is essential.

What It Does

Assuming you already have a Web site, you would like people to send you feedback or would like them to contact you when in doubt. So when they come to this feedback page (lets call it that, shall we?), they see a form wherein they can enter their details and queries. On clicking 'Submit', the form contents are processed using the PHP file and mailed to a pre-specified e-mail account. This can be any e-mail address in the whole wide world (or Web for that matter).

1 Understanding The Form

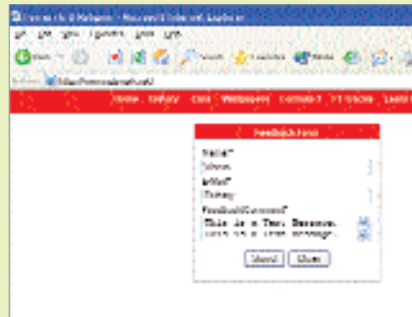
For the scope of this workshop, we will consider a simple form consisting of fields for 'Name', 'E-mail', and 'Feedback/Comment'. Also, the PHP file will be called feedback.php.

To create a form, you can use Microsoft FrontPage or Macromedia Dreamweaver. These will let you create

the forms in a single click, and you can proceed straight to the section about adding the PHP page and the reference in the form.

If you do not have the above-mentioned software, you will have to whip out Notepad and do it the good old manual way. If this page is going to have just this form, then, after you put in the <head>, <title> and <body> tags, you need to put in the code for the form.

The code has two parts: the field title (such as 'Name', 'E-mail', and so on), and the actual place where the data will be entered.



A Web-based e-mail form

2 Writing The Code

The first line that you need to write is:

```
<form method="POST" action="
www.nutswork.net/feedback.php">
```

This is the line that tells the browser to send the form data to the PHP file.

The URL must be absolute, i.e., it should incorporate the directory structure of your Web site. For instance, if you have made a directory in your Web site called 'phpforms' and have placed the feedback form in that directory, in the 'action' field above, your URL will become: 'www.nutswork.net/phpforms/feedback.php'

3 Adding The Fields

To add the input fields such as 'Name' or 'E-mail', you need to write the following lines of code exactly as they appear here. Make sure all the lines are between the <body> and </body> tags.

```
Name: <input type="text"
name="T1" size="20">
```

Here, "Name:" is what you will see when you open the page in the browser. This will be followed by an empty text box—more on that later.

Make note of the entry "name="T1"" inside the <> symbols. Here, 'T1' is the name of the input box and can be anything you choose, but make sure you remember it as we will be using it in our PHP file.

To create more fields such as 'E-mail' and 'Comment' simply use the above code with the name field changed. You should take care that no two fields can have the same name, so if you are calling the first field (i.e., the field where you are entering the users name) 'T1', then no other field on the same page can be called 'T1'.

When you create the field for 'Feedback/Comment', it will obviously be greater than the field for 'Name', 'E-mail', and so on. Go back to the code above and in place of input type="text" you must define your text box as:

```
<TEXTAREA style="WIDTH: 230px"
name=comments
cols=34></TEXTAREA>
```

4 Creating The Buttons

To submit the data to the PHP file, we need to tell the

browser that the form has been filled and needs to go for further processing. To do that, we need to create a button that will post the form on clicking it. To create the button, you will need to type the following in your Web page source code:

```
<input type="submit" value="Submit"
name="B1"><input type="reset"
value="Reset" name="B2">
```

This will give you two buttons, one to submit and the other to reset the form. Here, anything that you put in place of 'submit' in the value="submit" field will appear as on the button when you view the page.

Again, here name="B1" is the name of the button and should be remembered as well will use the reference in our PHP file. Once you are done creating the fields, don't forget to close the form code by adding </form>.

5 The PHP File

The first two characters that you need to enter are '<?.'